but also the ones we cannot. Gott also argues that establishing human communities on other worlds may offer us our best chance of beating the odds.

To take out this insurance policy is not very expensive, not on the scale on which we do things on Earth. It would not even require doubling the space budgets of the present spacefaring nations (which, in all cases, are only a small fraction of the military budgets and many other voluntary expenditures that might be considered marginal or even frivolous). We could soon be setting humans down on near-Earth asteroids and establishing bases on Mars. We know how to do it, even with present technology, in less than a human lifetime. And the technologies will quickly improve. We will get better at going into space.

A serious effort to send humans to other worlds is relatively so inexpensive on a *per annum* basis that it cannot seriously compete with urgent social agendas on Earth. If we take this path, streams of images from other worlds will be pouring down on Earth at the speed of light. Virtual reality will make the adventure accessible to millions of stay-on-Earths. Vicarious participation will be much more real than at any earlier age of exploration and discovery. And the more cultures and people it inspires and excites, the more likely it will happen.

But by what right, we might ask ourselves, do we inhabit, alter, and conquer other worlds? If anyone else were living in the Solar System, this would be an important question. If, though, there's no one else in this system but us, don't we have a right to settle it?

Of course, our exploration and homesteading should be enlightened by a respect for planetary environments and the scientific knowledge they hold. This is simple prudence. Of course, exploration and settlement ought to be done equitably and transnationally, by representatives of the entire human species. Our past colonial history is not encouraging in these regards; but this time we are not motivated by gold or spices or slaves or a zeal to convert the heathen to the One True Faith, as were the European explorers of the fifteenth and sixteenth centuries. Indeed, this is one